Calvin Isch

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RESEARCH SUMMARY

I study how people and AI systems reason about empirical evidence: how scientific claims are produced, communicated, and ultimately acted upon. Trained in cognitive science and computational social science, I combine large-scale text analysis, expert-validated LLM-based measurement, and behavioral experiments on judgment and social learning. My recent work quantifies causal overstatement across 194,631 social science articles (*Nature Human Behaviour*, 2026), identifies sycophantic distortion in LLM summaries of scientific research (*ACL* 2026), and examines whether adversarial collaboration can make scientific disagreement more productive (*Theory and Society*, 2025).

EDUCATION

Ph.D., University of Pennsylvania Expected May 2027

Communication (Computational Social Science), Annenberg School for Communication

Committee: Duncan J. Watts (chair), Philip E. Tetlock, Sandra González-Bailón, Yphtach Lelkes

M.A., Statistics and Data Science, The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania 2024

M.A.T., Relay Graduate School of Education, Indianapolis, IN 2022

B.S., Indiana University, Bloomington, IN 2020

Major: Cognitive Science | Minors: Liberal Arts and Management (Honors), Mathematics

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Isch, C., Dorr, T., Fasching, N., Jennings, G., & Watts, D. J. (2026). Quantifying the prevalence and impact of overreaching causal claims in social science. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 1-16.

Isch, C., & Jennings, G. (2026). Narrative license and model sycophancy in LLM summaries of scientific work. *Proceedings of the 64th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics* (Vol. 1: Long Papers), 16418–16432.

Isch, C., & Centola, D. (2026). Experimental evidence that social learning in structured information-sharing networks corrects anchoring bias. *Journal of Social Computing*, 7(1), 3–13.

Isch, C., Tetlock, P. E., & Clark, C. J. (2025). Reflections on adversarial collaboration from the adversaries: Was it worth it? *Theory and Society*, 1–18.

Isch, C. (2025). Media bias in portrayals of mortality risks: Comparison of newspaper coverage to death rates. *Social Science & Medicine*, 117542.

Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, & Shariff, A. (2024). Why do organizations take political stances? A review of reasons and risks. *Social and Personality Psychology Compass*, 18(7), e12985.

Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, Connor, P., & Tetlock, P. E. (2024). Assume a can opener. *Behavioral and Brain Sciences*, 47, e36.

Clark, C. J., Connor, P., & **Isch, C.** (2023). Failing to replicate predicts citation declines in psychology. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 120(29), e2304862120.

Isch, C., Brown, R., Todd, P. M., Aktipis, A., & Pepper, G. (2023). Objective risk exposure, perceived uncontrollable mortality risk, and health behaviors. *Journal of Public Health*, 1–11.

Isch, C., Ten Thij, M., Todd, P. M., & Bollen, J. (2022). Quantifying changes in societal optimism from online sentiment. *Behavior Research Methods*, 1–9.

Heiman, S. L., Hirt, E. R., **Isch, C.**, Brinkworth, J. F., Cronk, L., Alcock, J., … Todd, P. M. (2022). Identities as predictors of vaccine hesitancy during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Journal of Social Issues*.

Sonmez, G., & **Isch, C.** (2020). Do environmental resource distributions affect attentional styles? *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW AND IN PREP

Isch, C., Dutta, U., Schaerer, M., Uhlmann, E.L., Tetlock, P., Clark, C. Politics and causal overreach in the behavioral sciences. In revision at *Science Advances*.

Clark, C. J., **Isch, C.**, Everett, J. A. C., & Shariff, A. Even when ideologies align, people distrust politicized institutions. In revision at *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*. https://doi.org/10.31234/osf.io/sfubr

Isch, C., Aktipis, A., Todd, P.M. Awe, agency, and the future of humanity. In Preparation.

Isch, C. Miller, T. OpenSermon: A national archive of american church sermons. In Preparation.

RESEARCH INFRASTRUCTURE

OpenSermon — open archive and research platform for American sermons 2025–present
https://open-sermon.com

Built an end-to-end pipeline that identifies congregations, discovers and collects publicly available sermon media, transcribes it with open-source ASR, and applies validated LLM-based measures. Current beta covers 634 congregations and 49,034 sermons, updated weekly. Presented on a Presidential Panel at the Association for the Sociology of Religion.

GRANTS AND FELLOWSHIPS

Information and Democracy Research Grant ($15,000) 2026
Humane Studies Fellowship, Institute for Humane Studies ($17,000 total) 2024–2026
Summer Institute on Bounded Rationality, Max Planck Institute (fellow) 2023
Cox Research Scholarship, Indiana University (full tuition, merit-based) 2016–2020

HONORS

Teacher of the Year nomination, Indiana Math and Science Academy 2021
Phi Beta Kappa 2019

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

"Narrative License in Scientific Writing and LLM Summaries of Scholarship." CogLunch, Indiana University – October 2026

"Awe, agency, and the future of humanity." Cooperative Futures Institute, ASU / San Francisco — June 2026.

"Politics and causal overreach in the behavioral sciences." American Enterprise Institute — May 2026.

"Media portrayals of mortality risks / Using LLMs for large-scale qualitative analysis." New(s) Knowledge Conference, MIT — October 2025.

"Quantifying the prevalence of overreaching causal language in the social sciences." DARPA SCIFY — September 2025; PolNETs, Harvard — August 2025; IC2S2, Sweden — July 2025.

"On collaborating with adversaries: Lessons from those who have tried it." Philosophy of Science Association, New Orleans — November 2024.

"The political impact of virtue signaling." with professor Diana Mutz. FIRE Faculty Conference, Boston — October 2024.

"Narrative license in the social sciences: An exploration with GPT-4." AIMOS Conference, QUT Brisbane — November 2023.

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Ph.D. Candidate, University of Pennsylvania Aug 2022–present

- Built evaluation pipelines, validated against expert judgments, measuring sycophancy and causal overclaiming in summaries produced by six frontier LLMs.
- Designed large-scale retrieval and annotation workflows using proprietary and open-source models to classify hundreds of thousands of scientific and news articles.
- Designed and ran online experiments on anchoring, wisdom-of-crowds, social learning, and media effects.

Lead Teacher, Indiana Math and Science Academy North Aug 2020–Jun 2022

- Taught sixth-grade mathematics to 50–70 students annually; received the highest available administrator evaluation ("Accomplished") and founded Mathematician Monday, a speaker series on quantitative careers.

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Teach For America, 2020 corps member 2020–2022
Board of AEONS, advisory board to the President of Indiana University (faculty-nominated) 2019–2020
TEDxIndianaUniversity, Director of Curation — events with 1,000+ attendees 2016–2019

METHODS AND TOOLS

LLM evaluation design and expert-validated measurement; experiments and audits of AI systems; large-scale text analysis and NLP; multilevel, time-series, and panel models. Python, R, SQL, Git, AWS, Hugging Face, Claude Code, web scraping.

ULTRA ENDURANCE

Spartan Ultra Top 5 (2026); Sub 24-hour 100-miler (2025); 100 km ultramarathon champ (2024); Boston Marathon Qualifier